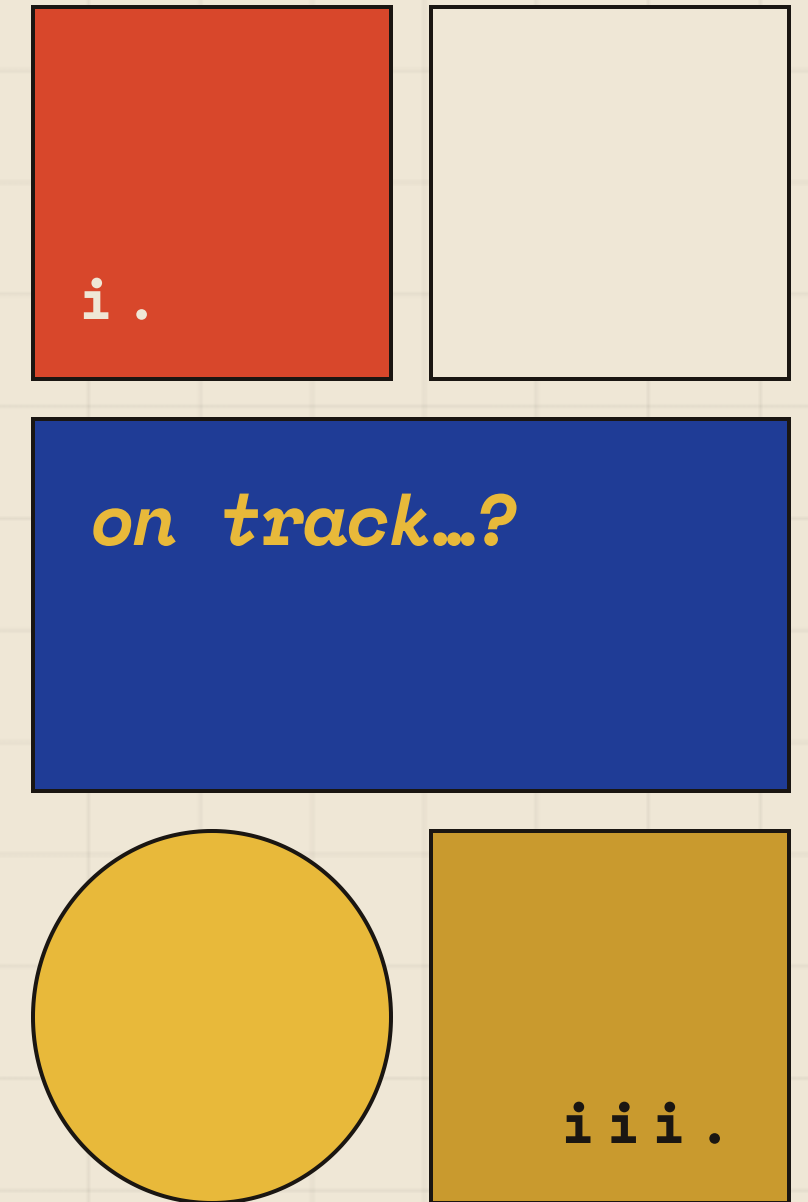




Solve the **right** problem. Build the **right** thing. Build the **thing** right.

How do you keep an AI-assisted brief honest?

Three questions, and the tool I built to ask them.



Three questions an *AI-assisted* brief has to answer honestly.



PART I.

Solve the *right* problem.

Did the AI help me audit the brief, or did it help me finish the brief? Have I named what's missing across all four lenses before I let the model run further?

ON TRACK WHEN

A human ran the audit. The AI flagged what it doesn't know. The thinnest lens is named, not papered over.



PART II.

Build the *right* thing.

Is the framework doing real thinking, or is the AI generating plausible structure? Pick for fit, not because the model offered it.

ON TRACK WHEN

A framework was filled in by a human, not auto-generated. It surfaced something the model wouldn't have predicted from the brief.



PART III.

Build the *thing right*.

Whose voice is on the page – mine, or the model's? Is every AI-generated claim flagged for verification before the deck goes out?

ON TRACK WHEN

Every AI sentence is sourced, flagged, or rewritten. [WOBBLY] [CS:] [ASSUMPTION] visible on the page. Voice stays mine.

Three ways AI quietly wrecks a brief before anyone *notices*.

PART I. FAIL The AI finished it before you <i>thought it</i>. The tell: the brief is fluent on WHAT and HOW. Thin on WHO and WHY. The model filled the gaps with plausible language and you let it. What it costs: six weeks of beautiful work pointed at a problem the AI invented for you.	PART II. FAIL The model picked the <i>framework</i>. The tell: the AI suggested POEMS or Jobs-to-Be-Done before you finished thinking. You used it because it was offered, not because it fit. What it costs: a deliverable that looks rigorous and explains nothing – generated structure, not earned structure.	PART III. FAIL The AI <i>cleaned</i> your voice out. The tell: you pasted the draft into the model and it came back smoother, smarter, and not yours. Nobody can tell who wrote it. Including you, in six months. What it costs: the work passes review and quietly fails to move anyone. Fluent ≠ true.
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An AI-assisted brief earns trust when it holds up in *four directions*.

WHAT · SYSTEMi. The <i>thing</i>. Name it. "Platform" when you mean "spreadsheet" is how the wrong problem walks into the room. ON TRACK Specific. Concrete. Could be photographed.	WHO · PEOPLEii. The <i>humans</i>. Specifically. Not "users". The ones you'd recognize walking into the room. ON TRACK Named segment. Real anxieties. Not a persona deck.
WHY · VALUEiii. The <i>change</i>. What shifts if it works. What flows – in money, attention, or trust. ON TRACK Stakes named. Failure mode legible. Solve right · Build right · Build right	HOW · MECHANICSiv. The <i>moves</i>. Steps, phases, sequence. Where the rubber meets the road, where money exits the bank. ON TRACK A first user could walk it. Without a guide.

When a lens is thin, a *framework* forces the model – and you – to do real work.

Frameworks aren't deliverables. They're *forcing functions* – and against AI they do specific work: they make you fill cells the model would have skimmed past. You read them back, and most of the time you throw them away.

Generative models converge on the statistically central answer. A framework yanks the work off-center.

Same back catalogue I've been teaching for fifteen years. The point isn't that they're new. The point is they still do the work the model won't.

WHAT

POEMS

*People · Objects ·
Environments ·
Messages · Services*

MAP THE TERRITORY

WHO

4As

*Ambitions ·
Anxieties ·
Attitudes · Actions*

GET UNDER THE
SKIN

WHAT

AEIOU

*Activities ·
Environments ·
Interactions ·
Objects · Users*

HOLD CONTEXT
WHOLE

WHO

Five HF

*Emotional · Cultural
· Social · Cognitive
· Physical*

THE WHOLE HUMAN

HOW

5Es

*Entice · Enter ·
Engage · Exit ·
Extend*

WALK THE JOURNEY

WHY

Value Web

*Map entities. Map
what flows.*

SEE WHAT'S
EXCHANGED

Reads. Scores. Names what's *thin*.

BRIEF

LIVE

A research school for design managers. Eight weeks. Cohort of 12 mid-career people promoted without training. They should leave with a portfolio of frameworks they actually used. Each week pairs one framework with one project they apply it to.

FOUR LENSES • AUDIT

WHAT						3/5
WHO						4/5
WHY						2/5
HOW						2/5

GEORGE'S COLUMN

- "design managers" – which ones? Two years in? Twenty...?
- WHY is 2/5. What *shifts* if they leave with frameworks they used...?
- HOW is thin. What's a "week" actually look like...?
- "portfolio" – for whom? A boss, a peer, themselves...?
- **WOBBLY** assumes "they want a portfolio" – verify.

GEORGE SUGGESTS A FRAMEWORK

4As

WHY is thinnest. **4As** – Ambitions, Anxieties, Attitudes, Actions – gets under "anxious about being found out". **TRADITION: 4As • IIT canon**

Drafts *in pieces*. Never finishes the dish.

Paul doesn't tighten a finished draft. Paul gives you **ingredients**. You bring a fragment – half a sentence, an instinct, a question with a tail on it – and Paul reflects back bullets, partial threads, named assumptions. The dish stays yours to assemble.

YOU | *Something about how silence in the brief isn't passive...?*

PAUL |

- negative space as active, not absence
- what the brief *doesn't* say defines it as much as what it does
- the unsaid is where assumptions hide ←
TRADITION: *Japanese ma · Bauhaus negative space*
WOBBLY *tying this to brief practice – practitioner intuition, not literature*
- the brief that is mostly white space might be the most honest one...?

YOU | *Right – and the "honest" part is what I want to land on...?*

PAUL |

- honesty in a brief = naming what you don't know yet ←
- "we haven't validated this" is more useful than "users want X"
- fragments + questions = working brief; full paragraphs = finished brief...?
ASSUMPTION *you mean intellectual honesty, not legal-disclaimer honesty*

Private space the AI *can't see*. Silent PM that doesn't sell you anything.

06 · JULIET

PRIVATE FREEWRITE

The *private* room.

A place to write what AI can't see. No mirror, no audit, no model. The thing you'd never paste into a chat box, by design.

- Separate localStorage key. Bradley has no read path.
- Two buttons: *save*, or *burn*.
- No turn counter. No suggestions. No witness you didn't invite.
- Named after 400 years of women writing letters to Verona.

Not every thought needs to be a deliverable.

02 · BRADLEY

SILENT PM

The *silent* PM.

Doesn't speak unless asked. Watches the work. Names where you are – and what comes next, as a guess from state.

- Next-room hint – *not a suggestion, a read*.
- Lens averages, framework count, refinements filed.
- Project log – every move except Juliet's.
- Works for the person, not the tool's quarterly numbers.

Anticipates. Doesn't advise.

The tool, *running*.

OPEN PROTOTYPE ↗

 **The House**
A BAND PROTOCOL

PROJECT

The Band

01 BRIEF

02 BRADLEY

03 GEORGE

04 FRAMEWORKS

05 PAUL

06 JULIET

07 LIBRARY

PROJECT BRIEF **SHARED**

Bring what you know. Fragments are fine. The brief is the seed — every room reads it.

What are you making? For whom? Why? What does done look like?

Drop fragments. Sentences. Lists. Anything you have. You'll refine it elsewhere.

Words: 0 Chars: 0 Last touched: —

WHERE TO NEXT

George reads briefs through four lenses — WHAT, WHO, WHY, HOW — and suggests a framework for the thinnest one. Paul refines drafts. The library holds what you've made.

OPEN GEORGE →

BROWSE FRAMEWORKS

TRY: DROP A BRIEF
 Solve right

THEN: WATCH THE LENSES SCORE
Build right

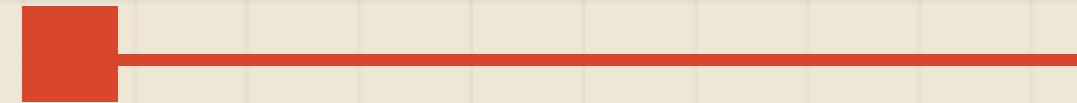
THEN: OPEN A FRAMEWORK
Build right

THEN: HAND PAUL A FRAGMENT

THEN: CHECK BRADLEY

— THREE THINGS TO TAKE

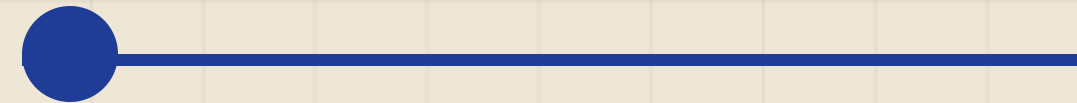
If the brief is *honest*,
the rest of the work knows it.



i. Solve right

**Audit the AI
before you ship.**

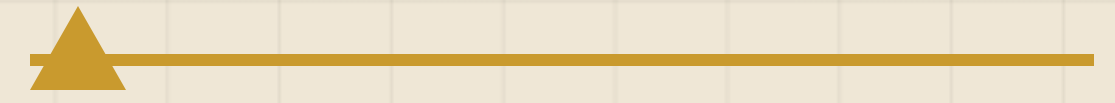
Run the four lenses on every AI-assisted brief. The cheap fix isn't a smarter model — it's a human catching what the model glossed over, in all four directions, before anyone signs off.



ii. Build right

**Frameworks are
forcing functions.**

POEMS, 4As, 5Es. The model will offer one. Pick for fit, not because it was offered. Fill the cells yourself — the AI's job is to widen options, not to choose.



iii. Build right

**Voice is the
seed.**

Draft in pieces. Let the model give ingredients — bullets, ellipses, **WOBBLY** tags, named assumptions. You assemble. You decide what's true. You decide what's done.

OPEN QUESTION

What would your version of George ask you about the last brief you handed an AI?